million migrant workers from Bengal are registered with the board, he lets on. Mamata has also pointed out that Bengal hosts nearly 15 million workers from other regions.

The TMC has cast its campaign as a battle for 'Bangaliyana', a composite Bengali identity that transcends religion and caste. The emotional charge around this is aimed squarely at consolidating support among Bengal's rural electorate, which provides the bulk of the migrant workforce.

BJP PUSHBACK

The BJP has pushed back hard. On the same day as Mamata's rally, Leader of the Opposition Suvendu Adhikari met West Bengal chief electoral officer Manoj Kumar Agarwal and flagged what he called an "abnormal rise in population" in the state's border districts. He cited the arrest of a suspected operative of the Bangladeshi militant organisation Ansarullah Bangla Team in Assam, who allegedly voted thrice in Bengal. Claiming that 80 of Bengal's 340 blocks are now "manned by officers who are illegal immigrants", Adhikari demanded an exhaustive combing of the voter rolls, akin to the special intensive revision in Bihar. Earlier, he had dismissed the TMC's allegations of persecution as deliberate exaggeration, stating that only Rohingya 'infiltrators' were being deported.

The TMC countered this breezy explanation with names and emotional testimonies, including those of Hindu victims. Some 200 migrant Bengali workers—among them Debashish Das from Hooghly—were detained and harassed in Odisha last week. Uttam Kumar Brojobasi, a Rajbanshi from Dinhata in Cooch Behar, reportedly received a Foreigners Tribunal notice from Assam despite living in West Bengal for over five decades. Even Bengal's Matua community, traditionally aligned with the BJP, is feeling the heat. Aarush Adhikari from Habra, working in Pune, was arrested despite possessing a Matua identity card issued by the BJP-linked All India Matua Sangha. "We're trying to get my brother out. He has all the documents," his brother Bhagirath says.



BACK HOME Three Bengalis who were earlier deported to Bangladesh pose after their repatriation by the BSF in Cooch Behar



"NO BENGALI HINDU AND NO INDIAN MUSLIM WILL HAVE TO PROVIDE ANY DOCUMENT TO PROVE CITIZENSHIP. THIS IS BENGAL BJP'S ASSURANCE"

SAMIK BHATTACHARYA
Bengal BJP president

Meanwhile, BJP state chief Bhattacharya declared, "No Bengali Hindu and no Indian Muslim will have to provide any document to prove their citizenship. This is Bengal BJP's assurance. TMC's ugly politics will backfire." But this statement, or its omission of the category 'Bengali Muslims', has intensified scrutiny of the BJP's position, especially in light of a statement from Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma on July 9 that it was easy to find out the number of Bengalis in Assam if all its speakers named 'Bengali' as their mother tongue during census. As his comments created a furore for trying to equate all Bengalis with "illegal Bangladeshi immigrants", Sarma denied he is 'anti-Bengali' and claimed that Bengali speakers in Assam understand his campaign against illegal infiltration.

The controversy has opened up larger questions around migration and governance. Garga Chatterjee, founder of the Bengali nationalist group Bangla Pokkho, criticised the West Bengal government for not doing enough to prevent the exodus of Bengali workers. "Why is there no reservation for Bengali speakers in government jobs?" he asks. "The TMC should focus on creating jobs instead of just exploiting the issue politically."

Yet Mamata has framed the issue in personal terms."I dare you to send me to a detention camp. I'll speak more in Bengali," she said on July 16. As Bengal hurtles toward 2026, the TMC's assertion that this is not just a political campaign but a cultural resistance movement may resonate beyond its traditional support base. Language, identity and dignity have become the central axes around which the state's politics will revolve in the coming months. ■